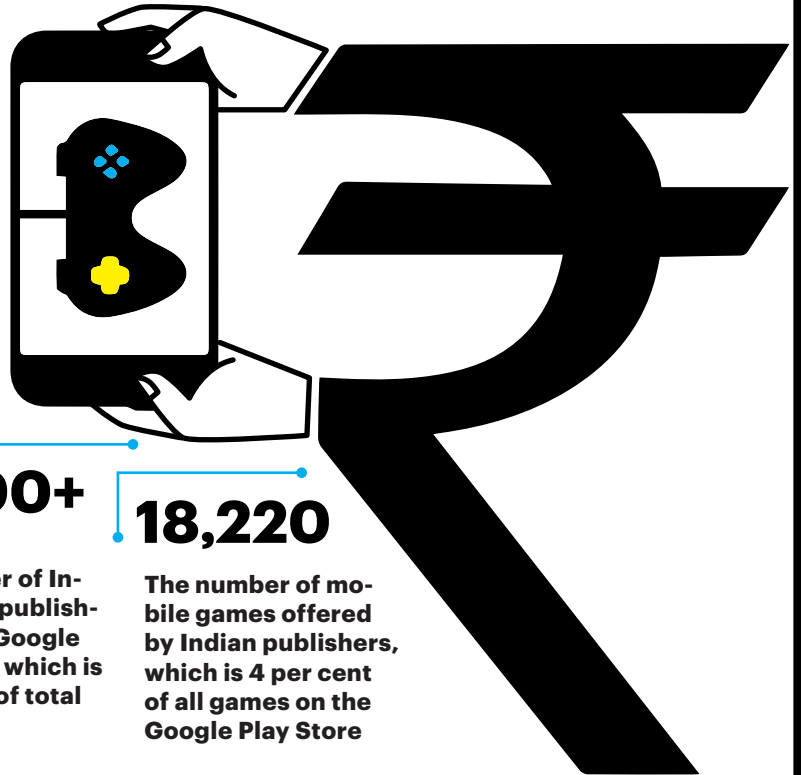


NO MORE CHILD'S PLAY

India's casual gaming industry has seen a meteoric rise in the past couple of years



₹14,500-15,000 crore

Size of the gaming market in India at the end of FY22

5,000+

The number of Indian game publishers on the Google Play Store, which is 3 per cent of total publishers

18,220

The number of mobile games offered by Indian publishers, which is 4 per cent of all games on the Google Play Store

SOURCE KPMG, 42MATTERS

installs in June 2022, growing from 300 million in December 2020. Not only did it attract an all-new demographic of players (45+ years) during the lockdown, it also turned gaming into a mainstream entertainment alternative and a social interaction tool.

Gamezop, meanwhile, licenses HTML5 games from developers and integrates it in non-gaming platforms like Amazon, MX Player, Vodafone, Airtel, etc. It has been pushing integrations aggressively after the pandemic. "In the first series of lockdowns, we were aggressively releasing these integrations, and saw the sharpest rise in user numbers. This was the *Ludo King* phase," says Agarwal, adding, "Today, gaming has become a lifestyle choice."

Besides social multiplayer games such as ludo, carrom, and pool that gained popularity during Covid-19, India is also seeing an uptick in games like *Battlegrounds Mobile India* (an Indianised version of *PUBG*) and cricket-based games, "which are evergreen", says KPMG.

"The market was dormant for a long time. Casual games were difficult to monetise. Then things started to change with the battle royale games (*PUBG*, *Free Fire*, *BMG*) that redefined the market. These game publishers have managed to get in-app-purchases (IAPs) on a very high scale, and are now generating \$150 million-plus in revenues a year for each title," says Piyush Kumar, Founder & CEO of Rooter Sports, a games streaming platform.

MONETISATION AND LOCALISATION

Monetisation has always been a challenge for any content business in India. And gaming is no different. While the sector



Gaurav Agarwal
Co-founder,
Gamezop

"THE PANDEMIC DID ONE THING FOR THE GAMING INDUSTRY: IT CONVERTED NON-GAMERS TO CASUAL GAMERS. GAMING FIRMS WERE AGGRESSIVE IN PUSHING THEIR GAMES SINCE PEOPLE HAD TIME ON THEIR HANDS"